Simulation/Game

FOREST TIMESCAPES

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KEYWORDS: *action planning; deforestation; forecasting; forest management; frame game; working with partners.*

Basic Data:

Instructional objective: To forecast and visualize changes in a critical area (such as forest management) in a series of specified future periods. To plan suitable action strategies based on these forecasts.
Game objective: To work with different partners and come up with best predictions and action plans.
Target audience: Participants interested in exploring environmental issues.
Playing time: 30 minutes to 2 hours. (The game can be shortened or lengthened by changing the number of time spans and the amount of discussion times for each round.)
Number of players: 4 or more; best game involves 10 to 25 participants.

Originally designed as a simulation game related to forestry management, this game can be used as a frame game for the exploration of any environmental or social issues.

Flow of the game

Brief the players. Present or review key factors and trends that affect forest management around the world. Involve players in a brief discussion of how these factors interact with each other.

Pair up the participants. Explain that the game involves 10 rounds of discussion during which each player will work with a different partner. Ask players to choose a partner for the first round.

Ponder on the distant future. Ask the first question: Thirty years from now, how would the world's forests look? How will the local communities manage these forests?

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Encourage participant pairs to discuss the topic and forecast changes in a variety of viewpoints such as environment, industry, science, technology, politics, international cooperation, and climate. Assign a suitable discussion time and suggest that partners take notes about the important elements in their forecast.

Conclude the first round. Ask partners to stop their discussion at the end of the allotted time. Ask a pair of volunteers to present a summary of their forecast. At the end of this presentation, invite any other pair of volunteers to present a better forecast. If nobody volunteers, then award 5 points to the first pair of volunteers. If another pair presents its better forecast, ask the remaining participants to vote on the two presentations and award 10 points to the winning pair. (This scoring arrangement is optional. If you prefer, you can just invite all volunteers to present their forecasts.)

Provide feedback. If appropriate, ask an expert to comment on these forecasts or give your comments. However, try lengthy lectures. Remember that the focus of this activity is to empower and encourage players to generate their own content.

Change partners. Ask each player to find a new partner for the next round of discussion.

Introduce the first action-planning discussion. Ask partners to think about the 30-year future and share the main points of their previous discussion with each other. Then ask them to develop the key elements of a 30-year forestry management plan to reduce or remove negative factors and to leverage positive ones. As before, assign a suitable discussion time.

Repeat the presentations and scoring round. As before, ask a volunteer pair to summarize the key elements of their plan. Invite other pairs to provide better or different ideas.

Conduct other rounds of discussion. Explain that the rest of the activity involves repeating the same procedure of finding a new partner, forecasting changes in forestry during a specified time period, sharing main points, finding a new partner, coming up with an action plan, and sharing key elements of the plan. Conduct these rounds with the following time periods:

- 30 months (2 years and 6 months)
- 30 weeks (about half of a year)
- 30 days

Conclude the activity with an immediate action plan. Ask players to work independently on this task. Ask each player to think back on the previous forecasts and plans and come up with a personal response to this question: What can I, as an individual, do after the next 30 minutes to take the first step in ensuring more efficient forest management by future generations? Announce a 3-minute time limit. After these 3 minutes, ask each player to find a new partner and share his or her personal plans.

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